Week 5

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 2 · LESSON 1

Worldview

BIG IDEA

A worldview is the set of lenses through which we see and interpret the world, shaping how we answer life's foundational questions and how we live. Students will compare naturalism, pantheism, and monotheism; leaders should not assume students already hold a biblical worldview, and should be patient as change comes slowly.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Like the speaker's first pair of glasses, a worldview changes everything you see; it is foundational, life-shaping questions about reality that dictate how you live.
2. Students will examine other popular lenses, naturalism and pantheism, then monotheism, because those views reach them through movies, music, art, TV, and books.
3. Do not assume your students have a biblical worldview; even churched kids often hold a 'buffet' worldview assembled from whatever looked good online.
4. The four worldview questions gently draw out what students think and reveal flaws in their thinking, so encourage honest answers, not expected ones.
5. Worldviews must be coherent and consistent; the buffet approach eventually fails, and Christianity is compelling because it is entirely coherent and consistent.
6. Do not expect students to change worldviews right away; changing how you see reality is a huge, anxious adjustment, so be patient and walk alongside them.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. What lenses are you already looking through, and where did they come from?
2. Where might your own worldview be a 'buffet,' with pieces that do not fit together?
3. How do movies, music, and media communicate naturalism or pantheism to you without saying so?
4. Is your group a place where students answer honestly rather than saying what leaders want to hear? How can you tell?

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WEEK 5 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Getting my first glasses

0:06 When I was 15, I remember going to my mom and telling her that I was having a hard time seeing what was in front of me — I was having a hard time seeing the board. I didn't think much of it — I just didn't think much of it. But I realized that sitting in the back of class, where I like to sit, I couldn't see anything. Then it got serious when I started to drive and realized that there were signs I thought I should be able to see, or that my friends had told me about, that I wasn't seeing. Something wasn't right. So I went to the doctors — I went to the eye doctor — and they did all the little checks.

0:44 They put the little thing on your face and do all the dialing, and you read the lines and the letters and all that kind of stuff, and I didn't think much of it. They told me to flip the lenses and say which one was better, and we did the whole process of getting fitted for a pair of glasses. I thought nothing of it — until the day I walked in and picked them up. I picked them up and looked at them, and for the first time I put glasses on, and all of a sudden the world completely changed. Things were sharper. I could see things across the room that I didn't even know existed. My entire perception, my entire reality, really started to change, because now I could actually see the way I was supposed to see.

What a worldview is

1:30 We're talking about worldviews. The most simplistic way to see it and understand it is this: you look at the world through a set of lenses, and how you look through those lenses dictates how you see the world. Worldview — how I view the world. But worldviews are more than that, and what you should now start to see through the worldview questions that were introduced is that worldviews are foundational. They are life-shaping questions about reality. It's not just the pair of glasses I'm looking through to see the world; it's literally how I'm interpreting it and how I'm living as a result of that view. Your students should see very quickly, through some of the activities in the Bible study, that a biblical worldview has a profound impact on how we live.

2:27 So this week I want you to keep three really important things in mind as you work through this lesson. We've talked about things like what apologetics is, and we've talked about what faith is. We've talked about what truth is. We've talked about logic. We've laid this foundation so that you can continue to move through this study. But now we need students to really understand what it means to see the world through a particular lens. And we don't just want them to see the world through the Christian lens. We want them to understand the world through a couple of other popular ways of seeing: naturalism and pantheism.

3:12 Then we're going to talk about what it looks like from a monotheistic worldview, because the way in which other people see the world is going to vastly, widely influence how your students

start to see the world. When people who see the world differently are involved in making movies and writing music and doing art and making TV shows and writing books and everything else, that worldview is going to get communicated to your students. So they need to start to be able to see that. But before we can start into all of that, there are three really important things I want you to keep in mind, because some things are going to come up here that are going to be pretty impactful.

Don't assume a biblical worldview

3:51 Number one: don't assume your students have a biblical worldview. If your group is a typical youth group where most of them call themselves Christians — where the majority are Christians — you might automatically assume that your students have a Christian worldview or a biblical worldview. That may not necessarily be the case. You're going to discover that your students have some inconsistencies and some contradictions in their worldview. In fact, worldviews are often — if you can imagine going to a buffet restaurant — worldviews are often like that now.

4:31 I mean, think about all the information we have. Think about what's available to our students via the internet: as soon as they want to know something, what do we ask? We ask Google, we ask Siri, we ask our questions over the internet to figure out the answers, rather than going to a library and looking at a book and considering the source. We just ask, and we look at the top five views on Google, and we go with it. Our students have more information available to them than at any other time in history.

5:02 So what happens is that students have what I call a buffet worldview. You walk into a restaurant that has a buffet, grab a plate, and you just start taking food that looks good; you just start grabbing whatever you want. Then when you're done with that, you get rid of that plate, you go back to the buffet, and you grab different stuff that looked good the next time — or maybe you go back and grab seconds of the stuff you really liked. But you grab it all together, and you eat at a very low, discounted price.

5:31 So you may automatically think that they have a biblical worldview, because somewhere along that buffet there are pieces of Christianity, pieces of Scripture in their worldview. But then, as you explore deeper — especially your small group leaders, as they explore deeper, get into more conversations, and build deeper relationships with those students — they're going to discover that there are some significant inconsistencies.

5:56 Now, don't panic. That's okay, because as we move through this process we'll hopefully iron out those inconsistencies and help them and guide them through a more consistent worldview. That's what the actual worldview questions are designed to do. By asking those four questions, it draws out what they think, but it also reveals the flaws in their thinking in a nice, gentle, respectful way. So make sure you encourage your students to answer honestly — and hopefully you've created that environment already. We don't want the answers they think we want to hear; we want their actual answers, whatever they may be. So don't freak out if you hear something that you totally did not expect.

Coherent and consistent

6:45 Number two: worldviews have to be coherent and consistent. Even though the buffet sounds really good and it works for some — or at least it seems like it works for some — it doesn't, and over time that will cause problems. That's why you go back for seconds and take different things: it's the search to figure out the best possible combination, and that doesn't work. So throughout this process we're going to be helping students understand that this is what makes Christianity so compelling — it is entirely coherent and it is entirely consistent.

Change takes time

7:20 And finally, don't expect students to change their worldview right away. Just because you see that they have a different worldview, or that they have inconsistencies in their worldview, or that there are some questions in their worldview, and you present the Christian worldview — even at the end of these 32 weeks — don't expect them to just go, "Oh, I'm going to put on a whole new pair of glasses and see the world totally differently." It doesn't work that way. In fact, it doesn't work that way at all. Changing how we see the world is not as easy as changing the prescription on a pair of glasses. It's a huge, huge adjustment.

8:02 In fact, it is sometimes so big that it causes discomfort and it causes anxiety, because to change how you see the world is to change almost your entire reality — how you understand things, how you answer the big questions in life, and how you interact with people. That's a lot of change. So be patient with your students. Walk alongside them. Help them figure it all out.

Looking back over four weeks

8:25 Over the last several weeks, we've challenged you with a lot of adjustments that you need to make within the context of your group. We've talked about the idea of building relationships being the most important thing — not just the relationship between your students and Christ, but your relationships between you and your students, and that there needs to be that sense of trust built. We've also talked about the idea of really just fostering a community where questions and doubt are welcomed.

8:54 We've talked about this idea of worldviews and what this looks like, and about being patient with your students in determining what their worldview actually is, and not being surprised if somehow their worldview doesn't quite line up with what you thought. And we've even talked about how to get rid of that barrier wall between what you're talking about in terms of objective truth and their view of truth, in the very postmodern, relativistic, post-truth kind of world that they're consistently exposed to in school and in media and whatnot. That's a lot. That's a lot to take in over the course of four weeks.

Take the pulse of your group

9:33 So now would be a really, really good time, if you haven't done so already, to check in with your small group leaders and check in with your other leaders to see how these things are going — to make sure that the community is starting to coalesce together, and that students feel like

they can ask the questions. Check in with some of your key students who have the pulse of the youth group, to get a feel for where everybody is and whether you are accomplishing these goals. It might look to you like you are, but don't be surprised if there's a little bit of angst and a little bit of struggle. And don't panic either if it's not happening just yet.

10:11 The important thing right now is to keep your hand on the pulse of your group, so that you can navigate it as you go and so that you are increasing that level of trust and increasing the students' ability to ask the tough questions. You might suddenly fall back into old questions that were asked in different lessons, because now students finally feel like they can ask that particular question, or answer that particular question that we're asking of them. So just be ready for it. Check in with your small group leaders, check in with a couple of students to figure out where everything is, and then strategize as to how you might move forward.

Three things to remember

10:49 But remember, when we're talking about worldviews, the three things you need to keep in mind are these: your students may not necessarily have the biblical worldview that you think they have; their worldview needs to not be a buffet, but coherent and consistent; and don't expect them to change it right away. Be patient — and I think that's probably the most important piece, to be patient with them. Pray with them. Continue to walk alongside them to help them understand truth and how it fits in, and how truth is going to change their reality, and how understanding Scripture and their understanding of truth is going to actually change their worldview slowly, but also profoundly.